STEADFAST

MEN

FROM THE BOOK STEADFAST MEN

Small-Group Guide

A meeting for every chapter

walksteadfast.com

Small-Group Guide

This guide is for the man who said yes when somebody asked him to host the table. You don't need to be a teacher. You need a room, a pot of coffee, a clock, and the willingness to go first when the room goes quiet.

Each chapter below gets one meeting, and the chapters the class spreads over two weeks get a second meeting with its own questions. The class week numbers match the Condensed Training map, so if your group is working through the twenty-four sessions, you can open this guide to the same week the video covers. If your group is reading the book on its own, ignore the week numbers and take the chapters in order.

How a meeting runs

Plan on seventy-five minutes. Start on time even if two men are still in the parking lot, and end on time even if the talk is good. Men come back to a table that keeps its word.

OPEN · 10 MINUTES

One question everybody answers, around the table, short. It gets every voice in the room early, and a man who has spoken once will speak again.

READ ALOUD · 5 MINUTES

One man reads the passage listed. Use whatever Bible he brought. Read the whole passage, not just the verse at the top of the chapter.

TALK · 40 MINUTES

Work the questions in order. You won't always get through them. Stopping on a good one is better than rushing to finish.

REPORT · 10 MINUTES

Each man says what he did with last week's Do this week line. Not what he meant to do. What he did. A miss gets said plainly and nobody piles on.

CLOSE · 10 MINUTES

Each man names his move for the coming week, out loud, and the man to his right prays for him by name. Short prayers. Plain words.

What the host does

Read the chapter before the men do. Answer the opening question first, and answer it honestly, because the men will go exactly as deep as you do and no deeper. When a man shares something heavy, thank him and let a little quiet sit before the next question. When one man talks too much, thank him by name and turn to someone who hasn't spoken. When a man needs more help than a table can give, a pastor or a counselor, help him get it that week and don't make him wait for the next meeting.

What's said at the table stays at the table. Say that out loud the first night and again any night a new man sits down. The one exception is when someone is in danger. Then you get help, and you tell him you're doing it.

The first night

The first meeting is different from the rest. Men don't know each other yet, or know each other only from the parking lot. Here's a simple way to run it.

Start with food if you can. Men talk easier with something in their hands. Then sit down and say why you're there. Keep it short. You might say something like this: "I'm not an expert. I'm a man who needs other men, and I'm guessing you are too. We're going to read a book together, one chapter a week, and do one thing each week. That's it."

Go around the table and have each man give his name, where he works or worked, who's at home, and one reason he came. Answer first yourself.

Then say the table rules out loud. We start on time and end on time. What's said here stays here, unless someone is in danger. Nobody fixes anybody. Every man answers the questions, and any man can pass.

Hand out the books, or make sure every man has one. Show them the Your Turn at the end of each chapter and explain that each week's homework is one page. Then work the chapter one meeting below. If the first night runs short, that's fine. Send men home early with the chapter to read and the first Your Turn page to work.

When something hard comes up

Sooner or later a man will say something heavy. A marriage on the edge. A son who won't speak to him. A secret he's carried for twenty years. A darkness that won't lift. Here's what helps.

Thank him for saying it. Don't rush to the next question, and don't let the table rush to advice. Let a little quiet sit. Then ask him one question: what would help most right now? Sometimes the answer is prayer. Sometimes it's a brother to call that week. Sometimes it's a pastor or a counselor, and if so, help him make that call before he leaves or within a day.

Check on him before the next meeting. A text is fine. A call is better.

If a man talks about hurting himself or someone else, or about a child being harmed, that's not something the table holds. Get help that night, and tell him you're doing it.

PART ONE

The Man You Were Built to Be

These first seven meetings lay the ground the rest of the book stands on. Expect the first two nights to feel stiff. Men are sizing each other up, deciding whether this table is safe. Your job is to make it safe by going first. By the third meeting the four marks are on the table, and from then on you'll hear men use them on each other. That's the point.

A word for the host on Part One. Don't let the marks turn into a slogan the group recites. The marks are meant to be done. When a man says "I need to work on going first," ask him where, and with whom, and by what day.

CHAPTER 1 · CLASS WEEK 1

A Quiet Tuesday

FOR THE HOST

This first night sets the tone for every night after it. Men will want to talk about big things, calling and purpose and the state of the world. Keep pulling them back to last Tuesday. The chapter's whole argument is that the small, unwatched hours are where a man is actually made, and a group that learns to talk about ordinary days will be able to talk about anything later. Answer the opening question first, and make your answer plain and a little unflattering.

OPEN

What did you do last Tuesday between getting home and going to bed?

READ ALOUD

Luke 16:10-12, then Matthew 7:24-27.

TALK

1. The chapter says a man's life gets settled on ordinary days. Do you believe that? What would have to be true for it to be wrong?
2. Name one small thing you do every weekday without thinking about it. Is it building something, or wearing something down?
3. In the story Jesus tells, both houses got the same storm. What was the only difference? Why do you think He put the difference in what the men did instead of what they heard?
4. Where in your week does nobody see you? What happens there?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Daniel 6:10.

5. Daniel prayed three times a day, the same way he always had, even when it could cost him his life. What does a habit like that protect in a man?
6. What's one ordinary thing you do every day that you'd want your grandkids to know you did?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man picks one spot in his Tuesday he'll handle differently this week, and says it out loud.

CHAPTER 2 · CLASS WEEK 2

You Are Not Crazy

FOR THE HOST

Many men carry a quiet suspicion that they're the only one confused about what a man is supposed to be. This meeting is where they find out they aren't. Let the contradictions come out, even the funny ones. Don't rush to fix them. The chapter ends by promising a line worth spending a life on, and that line comes next week. Tonight is for naming the mess honestly.

OPEN

Who taught you the most about what a man is, for good or bad?

READ ALOUD

Genesis 1:26-31.

TALK

1. Name two things you were told about manhood that can't both be true. Who told you each one?
2. Which voice has the loudest say over you right now, your dad, your friends, your job, your phone, or your church? Is it the one you'd choose?
3. God made man in His image and then gave him work and called it good. What does it change to think of work as part of the design and not just the curse?
4. Read the line you wrote this week about the work a man is here to do. Did you write the one you believe or the one you live?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Psalm 8.

5. David looks at the night sky and asks what man is that God would think of him. How does that question change when you ask it on a bad day?
6. If a twelve-year-old boy asked you what a man is for, what would you tell him?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man reads his line to the man beside him, and that man reads his back.

CHAPTER 3 · CLASS WEEK 3

The Four Marks

FOR THE HOST

Tonight the four marks come onto the table. Resist teaching them like a lecture. The chapter already did that. Your job is to help each man find which mark runs strong in him and which runs faint, because that's where his work is. If a man claims all four are strong, ask his wife's opinion, kindly, and watch the table laugh. Then ask him again.

OPEN

Which of the four marks came easiest to you this week, and which one did you avoid?

READ ALOUD

1 Corinthians 16:13-14, then Philippians 2:5-8.

TALK

1. Say the sentence at the center of the book together, once, from memory if you can. Which word in it lands hardest on you?
2. Paul tells the Corinthians to stand firm and then, in the same breath, to do everything in love. Why do you think he put those side by side?
3. Every man has a mark that runs strong and a mark that runs faint. Name yours. Where did the faint one get faint?
4. Philippians 2 shows Christ doing all four before He ever asked it of anyone. Where do you see each one in that passage?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Joshua 1:6-9.

5. God tells Joshua three times to be strong and courageous, and ties it to keeping His word. Why would courage depend on that?
6. Which mark would the people closest to you say is strongest in you? Would they be right?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man names one small thing he'll do this week that belongs to his faint mark.

CHAPTER 4 · CLASS WEEK 4

Stop Waiting

FOR THE HOST

Most men aren't lazy. They're waiting, for a feeling, a better season, or someone else to move. This chapter names that waiting as something God takes seriously. Keep the talk concrete. A man who says he's been waiting to get serious about God should leave with a time, a place, and a first step. Write each man's thing down so you can ask him about it by name next week.

OPEN

What's one thing you've been meaning to do for more than a month?

READ ALOUD

James 4:13-17, then Genesis 3:8-10.

TALK

1. James calls it sin to know the good you ought to do and not do it. Why do you think he's that blunt about it?
2. What do you tell yourself while you wait? "After this busy stretch." "When I feel ready." "When she stops being upset." Which line is yours?
3. God called out to Adam, "Where are you?" What was Adam doing when God asked? What would it have looked like for him to answer straight?
4. What's the smallest real move you could make on your thing before noon on a workday?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Luke 9:57-62.

5. The men in this passage all had a reason to wait. Which reason sounds most like yours?
6. What would it cost you to keep waiting another year?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man names his thing and the day he'll make the first move. The man to his right asks him about it next week.

CHAPTER 5 · CLASS WEEK 5

Pick Up the Weight

FOR THE HOST

Watch for two kinds of men tonight. One carries too little and knows it. The other carries everything, the job, the bills, his parents, his church, and calls it faithfulness while his family gets what's left over. Both need this chapter. Help the second man see that picking up the weight starts with what's actually his, and that a full calendar can still leave the main thing on the floor.

OPEN

What's something at your house that's yours to carry and you know it?

READ ALOUD

Galatians 6:1-5.

TALK

1. Paul says carry each other's burdens and then, a few lines later, each one should carry his own load. How can both be true?
2. Some men carry too little. Some carry the wrong things and call it responsibility. Which way do you lean?
3. The chapter says absence bought with a bigger paycheck is still absence. Where does that hit you?
4. Is there a weight somebody else dropped that landed on you? What does it look like to carry it without bitterness?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Genesis 3:17-19.

5. Work got harder after the fall, but it didn't stop being the man's to do. What does that say about the weight you carry?
6. Who carried weight for you when you were young, and did you ever thank them?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man names one thing he'll give his household this week that money can't buy.

Go First

FOR THE HOST

Going first is the mark men most often confuse with being loud or in charge. The shepherd in John 10 leads by walking ahead and taking the risk first. Keep steering the talk toward the costly, quiet kinds of going first: the first apology, the first prayer out loud, the first hard conversation. Be ready to tell the table about a time you went first and it went badly. Men need to see that a failed attempt still counts.

OPEN

When was the last time you were the first one to say sorry?

READ ALOUD

John 10:1-11.

TALK

1. The shepherd brings the sheep out and goes on ahead of them. What's the difference between pushing people and going ahead of them?
2. Where does your family, your crew, or your church need someone to step out first right now?
3. What keeps you from going first? Fear of being wrong, fear of looking foolish, or not wanting the blame if it goes bad?
4. The chapter says your number is second. What does it free you from to know Christ already went out ahead of you?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Nehemiah 2:11-18.

5. Nehemiah looked at the broken walls by night before he said a word. What do you need to see clearly before you step out?
6. Where is God asking you to go first in a place you'd rather follow?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man picks one door for the week. Pray out loud at the table, apologize without a "but," or name a mess to the people living in it.

CHAPTER 7 · CLASS WEEK 7

Work for God's Pay

FOR THE HOST

Be careful with the theology tonight. The pay in this chapter is the Lord's inheritance given to His children. It's never wages that earn a man his salvation. If a man starts to sound like he's trying to earn God's favor, read Ephesians 2:8-9 again and let it settle. The rest of the night is about the hidden life, the kindness nobody sees, the work done well when the boss is gone.

OPEN

What did you do last week that nobody noticed?

READ ALOUD

Colossians 3:22-24, then Ephesians 2:8-10.

TALK

1. Everybody works for some kind of pay. Money, praise, being needed, being left alone. What pays you?
2. The pay in Colossians is an inheritance, given to sons, not earned by workers. How does Ephesians 2 keep that straight?
3. Matthew 6 tells us to give and pray where nobody sees. Why does the hidden part matter so much to God?
4. What would change at your job if you did it for the Lord and nobody else was watching?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read 1 Corinthians 3:12-14.

5. Paul says the fire will test each man's work. What kind of work comes through fire?
6. If nobody ever thanked you again for anything, what would you keep doing?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man does one kindness this week nobody will hear about, and next week he reports only that he did it, not what it was.

PART TWO

What You Inherited, and What Is Yours

Part Two is the heaviest stretch of the book, and it's where a table either becomes a brotherhood or quietly falls apart. Fathers, anger, escape, the handoff from home, loneliness, and the sin inside a man all come up in these weeks. Some men will say more than they ever have. Some will go quiet and stop coming.

Host, call the man who misses. Don't wait for him to come back on his own. And watch the clock more carefully than you did in Part One. A night that runs long because a man opened up is a gift once. Every week, it wears men out.

This is also the stretch where a man may need more than the group. If a man talks about abuse, about hurting himself, or about violence at home, take it seriously that same night. Help him find a pastor or a counselor and stay with him until he does.

CHAPTER 8 · CLASS WEEK 8

The Empty Chair

FOR THE HOST

This is often the hardest meeting of the whole book. Some men had good fathers and will feel awkward saying so. Some had absent or cruel fathers and will say very little. Both are welcome. Don't press a quiet man to tell more than he wants to. Go first yourself, briefly and honestly, and then let silence do some of the work. Remind the table that the letter they write this week isn't for sending.

OPEN

Name one thing your father taught you without meaning to.

READ ALOUD

Psalm 68:4-6.

TALK

1. What sat in the chair at your table growing up? A good man, a hard man, a tired man, or nobody?
2. What did you need from your father that never came? It's fine to keep the answer short.
3. What thanks is true, even if the rest is hard?
4. The chapter says who sat in that chair was handed to you, and what you do with it now is yours. Where are you still letting the chair decide for you?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read 2 Samuel 18:31-33.

5. David weeps for a son he failed. What does his grief tell you about fathers and sons?
6. What would you want your own children to write in a letter to you someday?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man commits to writing the letter he won't send, and keeping it.

CHAPTER 9 · CLASS WEEK 9

Anger, the Itch, and the Drift

FOR THE HOST

Anger, the itch, and the drift are three different exits from the same pain. Some men will see themselves in one immediately. Others will say they don't have a problem and then describe an hour of scrolling every night. Keep the tone level. Nobody at the table gets shamed. Every man gets one real step that fits in a week, and a brother who asks him about it.

OPEN

When you've had a bad day, what do you reach for first?

READ ALOUD

Ephesians 4:25-32.

TALK

1. Anger, the itch, and the drift. Which one is your usual exit? Has it changed over the years?
2. Paul says in your anger do not sin, and don't give the devil a foothold. What does a foothold look like in your house?
3. The chapter calls every escape a door out of your own house. Who's left standing in the house when you walk out?
4. What pain is your exit trying to answer? Who should you be talking to instead?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Genesis 4:3-8.

5. God warns Cain that sin is crouching at the door. What did Cain need to do with his anger before it got out of hand?
6. What's the pain under your exit, if you named it in one word?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man names the first step for his escape that fits in seven days. A dark screen evening, one man who hears everything, or a cooling off rule he'll keep.

CHAPTER 10 · CLASS WEEK 10

The Father Who Does Not Leave

FOR THE HOST

After two heavy weeks, this chapter brings the good news. God is the Father who doesn't leave. Give the reading from Luke 15 plenty of room, and read it slowly. Many men picture God as a sterner version of their own dad. Tonight is a chance to set that picture next to the father in the story who was watching the road and ran.

OPEN

What's a word or a picture that comes to mind when you hear "God the Father"?

READ ALOUD

Luke 15:11-24.

TALK

1. Where did your picture of God as Father come from? How much of it came from your own dad?
2. In the story, the father sees his son a long way off and runs. What does it tell you that he was watching the road?
3. The younger son had a speech ready. Did he get to finish it? Why does that matter?
4. What would it look like to talk to God like a son this week and not like an employee?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Romans 8:14-17.

5. Paul says the Spirit lets us cry out "Abba, Father." What would it take for that word to feel natural to you?
6. When did you last ask God for something the way a son asks his dad?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man says "Father" out loud before his feet touch the floor every morning this week, and gives Him one sentence about the day.

When Home Never Handed You Off

FOR THE HOST

This chapter takes two meetings because it covers a lot of ground, from the blessing a man never got to the honor he still owes. In the first meeting, let men tell their story. In the second, turn toward what they'll do about it. Watch for bitterness that sounds like wisdom. Leaving home well means giving God the debt, and some men will need more than one week to get there.

OPEN

When did you first feel like a man? Did anyone tell you that you were one?

READ ALOUD

Genesis 32:22-32.

TALK

1. Some men were handed off well, some badly, and some never. Which was yours?
2. Jacob wrestled all night and would not let go without a blessing. What blessing have you been wrestling for?
3. Jacob walked away with a new name and a limp. What does it mean that God gave him both?
4. What do you still owe your parents, and what do they owe you that you'll never collect?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Ruth 1:16-17.

5. Ruth left her home without cutting off the one who came with her. What can a man learn from how she left?
6. What blessing could you give a young man this year that you never got?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man names one honest sentence he'd want to hear from an older man.

When Home Never Handed You Off

OPEN

Who is an older man whose life you'd want yours to look like?

READ ALOUD

Ephesians 6:1-4, then Genesis 2:24.

TALK

1. A man can leave home without slamming the door. What would that look like for you?
2. Honoring your father and mother isn't the same as obeying them forever. Where's the line for a grown man?
3. Give God the debt. What would it take to stop waiting for an apology that may never come?
4. Who's a younger man you could tell, plainly, that you see a man when you look at him?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Younger men make the ask of an older man. Older men say the word to a younger one. Both report back next week.

A Man With No Brothers

FOR THE HOST

Loneliness is the quiet epidemic among men, and most of them will not call it that. The first meeting names it. The second meeting is about building something that lasts past the first awkward month. Make the ask feel normal. You might pair men up yourself if nobody moves. Check in on those pairs by name for the next several weeks.

OPEN

Who would you call at two in the morning?

READ ALOUD

Ecclesiastes 4:9-12.

TALK

1. Most men have buddies and no brothers. What's the difference?
2. When did you last have a friend who knew everything about you? What happened to that?
3. Ecclesiastes says pity the man who falls with nobody to help him up. Where have you been falling alone?
4. What makes it hard for men to ask another man for time?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Mark 2:1-5.

5. Four men carried their friend and dug through a roof to get him to Jesus. Who would carry you like that? Who would you carry?
6. What gets in the way of men being honest with each other, even at church?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man makes one ask before the next meeting. Twenty minutes a week for three months, with the day and the hour settled before he hangs up.

A Man With No Brothers

OPEN

Did you make the ask? How did it go?

READ ALOUD

1 Samuel 18:1-4, then 1 Samuel 20:41-42.

TALK

1. Jonathan gave David his robe and his sword. What did that cost him?
2. What's one honest question you could ask a brother that most men never ask each other?
3. What would it take for this table to be a place where a man could say the worst thing about himself and still be welcome next week?
4. Same hour, no matter what. What keeps a weekly meeting with a brother alive past the first month?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each pair confirms their day and hour out loud in front of the table.

The Problem Inside

FOR THE HOST

This chapter moves from what was done to a man to what is in him. It can feel like a hard turn after the father chapters. Help men hold both together. The harm done to them was real, and their own sin is real too. In the second meeting, spend real time on forgiveness. Men who confess well but never believe they're forgiven will drift back into hiding.

OPEN

What's a habit you've tried to quit more than once?

READ ALOUD

Mark 7:14-23.

TALK

1. Jesus says what comes out of a man is what makes him unclean. Why is that harder to hear than "your circumstances made you do it"?
2. If your father had been perfect, what trouble would still be in you?
3. Paint was never the fix. Where have you been painting over something instead of naming it?
4. Why do you think naming sin out loud is so much harder than feeling bad about it?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Psalm 51.

5. David wrote this after he was caught. What does he ask God for that's more than forgiveness?
6. What's the difference between being sorry you got caught and being sorry you did it?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man gives God two minutes every night this week, names that day's sins one at a time, and thanks Him.

The Problem Inside

OPEN

What did you notice about your nights this week?

READ ALOUD

1 John 1:5-10, then Romans 8:1.

TALK

1. Guilt says "I did something wrong." Shame says "I am something wrong." Which one shows up for you after you confess?
2. 1 John says if we confess, He is faithful to forgive. What does "faithful" add to that promise?
3. Romans 8 says there is no condemnation for those in Christ. Do you live like that's true?
4. Who at this table, or in your life, needs to hear you name something you've only told God?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man names one place shame tried to take over the conversation this week, and what he'll say back to it.

CHAPTER 14 · CLASS WEEK 17

No Fixed Star

FOR THE HOST

Every man at the table steers by something. Tonight is about naming it and setting it beside the one fixed point. Many men are embarrassed by how little they read the Bible. Make that easy to admit, because nothing changes until it's said. Then help each man leave with a plan small enough to keep for four weeks, a section of Mark a day, read aloud if he can.

OPEN

What do you measure yourself against when you want to feel like you're doing okay?

READ ALOUD

Amos 7:7-8, then 2 Timothy 3:14-17.

TALK

1. Dad, the guys around you, the culture, feelings, success. Which one have you been steering by?
2. A plumb line doesn't argue and doesn't take a vote. Why is that both hard and good news?
3. Paul names four jobs for Scripture, teaching, rebuke, correction, and training. Which one have you been avoiding?
4. What's kept you from reading the Bible steadily? Be honest. Then name what would get you through four weeks.

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Psalm 1.

5. The man in this psalm is like a tree planted by water. What keeps a tree steady when the weather turns?
6. What time of day, and what place, could you give to the Bible every day for the next month?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man commits to a section of Mark every day this week, writing one line about what it asks a man to do.

PART THREE

The Story That Names You

Part Three is short and it's the hinge of the book. Everything before it was about the man you are and what you were handed. Everything after it is about what you build. In between, the book goes back to the two gardens and to the Man who finished what the first man dropped.

Host, these meetings are more Bible and less story than the others. That's fine. Give the reading more time. Let men ask the questions they've been embarrassed to ask. If you don't know an answer, say so, write it down, and bring back what you find, or ask your pastor.

Two Men, Two Ways

FOR THE HOST

These two meetings carry the big story of the book, the first man and the second Man. Don't let them turn into a theology debate. The point is personal. Every man was born into Adam's pattern of hiding and blaming, and every man in Christ is counted in the second Man's obedience. If questions come up you can't answer, write them down and bring an answer back next week.

OPEN

When you hear "Adam," what comes to mind first?

READ ALOUD

Genesis 2:7-17, then Genesis 3:1-13.

TALK

1. Before anything went wrong, God gave the man work, a word to keep, and a garden to tend. Why do you think the work came before the wife?
2. Where was Adam while the serpent was talking? What does his silence look like in a man today?
3. Adam blamed the woman and, in a way, blamed God. When you get caught, who do you blame first?
4. You were born in the first man's garden. Where do you see his pattern in your own week?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Hebrews 2:14-18.

5. Jesus was made like His brothers in every way and was tested. What does it mean to you that He faced what you face and didn't fall?
6. What would change in your week if you believed you were counted in the second Man?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man reads Genesis 1 and 2 aloud in one sitting before the next meeting.

Two Men, Two Ways

OPEN

Did you read Genesis aloud? What stood out hearing it?

READ ALOUD

Matthew 26:36-46, then Romans 5:17-19.

TALK

1. The first man was in a garden and said no to God. The second Man was in a garden and said "not My will, but Yours." Put those side by side. What do you see?
2. Paul says through one man's disobedience many were made sinners, and through one Man's obedience many will be made righteous. What does it mean to you that you're counted in the second Man?
3. Where are you most likely to face your own garden choice this week?
4. "It is finished" is the last word on you in Christ. How would you live differently if you believed that on a bad Tuesday?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man picks the moment he's most likely to face this week and the line from Gethsemane he'll say when it comes.

CHAPTER 16 · CLASS WEEK 20

Destiny Is Not a Vibe

FOR THE HOST

Men in their twenties often feel they haven't found their destiny yet. Men in their fifties often feel they missed it. This chapter speaks to both. Destiny is the plain work God hands you, in your place, for your people, in these years. Keep the cards concrete. A line like 'be a better dad' isn't a card. 'Breakfast with my son Saturday at seven' is.

OPEN

What did you think you'd be doing with your life when you were twenty?

READ ALOUD

Acts 13:36, then Ephesians 2:10.

TALK

1. David served God's purpose in his own generation, and then he died. Why is that a better epitaph than "he followed his dreams"?
2. Place, people, hands, and these years. Which one have you been ignoring while you wait for something bigger?
3. Where has a feeling been standing in for a calling in your life?
4. What good work has God already prepared that's sitting right in front of you?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Jeremiah 29:4-7.

5. God told exiles to build houses, plant gardens, and seek the good of a city they didn't choose. What does that say to a man who feels stuck where he is?
6. What's one thing God has already put in your hands that you've been treating as small?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man writes his card with the four headings and names one thing from it he'll do before next Tuesday.

PART FOUR

The House

Part Four is about the house a man keeps. A wife, or the life he's living if there isn't one yet. The marriage bed. A daughter. A son. Some of your men are married, some single, some divorced, some widowed. Make sure every man knows he belongs at the table for every one of these meetings.

Host, two cautions. First, a married man talking about his wife at the table is talking about someone who isn't in the room. Keep the talk about what he will do, not a list of what she does wrong. Second, the meeting on the marriage bed needs a steady hand. Keep it honest and clean. If a man needs to say more about porn or an affair than the group should carry, set up a time with him and one other trusted man that same week.

CHAPTER 17 · CLASS WEEK 21

If There Is No Wife Yet

FOR THE HOST

This meeting matters as much for the married men as for the single ones. Single men often feel like guests at church. Married men often forget them. Make sure the single men speak first tonight. If a man is single again after a divorce or a death, give him room and don't rush him toward the next relationship. The chapter's point is that he's already a whole man with real work to do.

OPEN

Married men, what do you wish you'd done with your single years? Single men, what's one thing you're glad about in this season?

READ ALOUD

1 Corinthians 7:32-35, then Genesis 2:15.

TALK

1. Paul says the unmarried man can give himself to the Lord without a divided mind. What could undivided attention look like for a single man this year?
2. No wife yet still leaves you a man. What lies do single men tell themselves about that?
3. For men who are single again, what does God's word say to you that the culture doesn't?
4. Married men, how can you make room in your house and your week for a single brother?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Genesis 2:18-20.

5. Before God brought the woman, He gave the man work and named his loneliness out loud. What does that tell a single man about where he stands with God?
6. What's one way this table could make sure no single man sits alone on a Sunday?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each single man names one thing he'll get done this week. Each married man names one single brother he'll have over.

CHAPTER 18 · CLASS WEEK 22

Know Her

FOR THE HOST

Keep the talk on what each man will learn about her, not on what she should learn about him. Some men will be surprised how little they know. That's a good night. Single men can work this chapter with a mother, a sister, or a friend's family. The question from the Do this week line is the heart of it, and the listening is harder than the asking.

OPEN

What's one thing about your wife, or your mom, or a sister, you learned only recently?

READ ALOUD

1 Peter 3:7-9.

TALK

1. Peter tells husbands to live with their wives in an understanding way. What's the difference between knowing about her and knowing her?
2. She kept living after you stopped taking notes. When did you stop?
3. Peter ties the way a man treats his wife to whether his prayers are hindered. Why would God link those two?
4. What's your weakest area in knowing her? Her fears, her hopes, her days, her history?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Proverbs 31:10-12, 28-31.

5. The husband in Proverbs 31 knows his wife well enough to praise her at the gates. When did you last praise her where others could hear?
6. What do you think she'd say you understand least about her?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each married man picks one question from his weakest area to ask this week, and listens all the way through. Single men ask it of their mother, sister, or a friend's wife with her husband present.

Lay It Down

FOR THE HOST

This is the last chapter of the twenty-four class weeks, and it's about the hardest thing a husband does, laying down what he wants for his wife's good. Expect resistance dressed up as reasonableness. Keep coming back to Christ, who laid down more than any of us will. In the second meeting, take time to look back over the whole stretch since the first Tuesday, and ask the men what's next for the group.

OPEN

What's an argument at your house you've had more than five times?

READ ALOUD

Ephesians 5:21-30.

TALK

1. Paul tells husbands to love their wives as Christ loved the church and gave Himself up for her. What did that cost Christ?
2. Being right is not the same as being a husband. Where have you been winning arguments and losing your wife?
3. What are you clutching right now? Your schedule, your money, your hobby, your pride?
4. Why is "What do you need from me that you're not getting?" such a hard question to ask?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Ruth 3:7-11 and Ruth 4:9-10.

5. Boaz protected Ruth's name and paid the price to redeem her. What does it look like for a husband to guard his wife's name?
6. What's one argument you could stop trying to win this month?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each married man asks her that question this week, with no defending, and does the first thing she names.

Lay It Down

OPEN

Did you ask the question? What did she say, as much as you're willing to share?

READ ALOUD

Philippians 2:3-8, then John 13:1-15.

TALK

1. Jesus knew all things had been put in His hands, and then He picked up a towel. What does it tell you that power and service went together for Him?
2. Laying it down isn't the same as checking out. What's the difference between a man who serves and a man who just stops leading?
3. What's one thing in your house that only gets done if you lay down something you'd rather keep?
4. This is the last meeting of the twenty-four class weeks. What's changed in you since the first Tuesday?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man names the thing he laid down this week and the one he'll lay down next. If your group is going on, set the date for the next meeting before anyone stands up.

CHAPTER 20

The Bed Is a Covenant

FOR THE HOST

Lead this meeting with care. Keep the talk honest, plain, and clean. Don't ask for details nobody needs. Some men are carrying secrets about porn or an affair that the whole group shouldn't hear first. Make it clear you're available after the meeting, and help any man who needs it find one trusted brother and, if needed, a pastor or counselor.

OPEN

What did you learn about sex growing up, and who taught you?

READ ALOUD

Hebrews 13:4, then Song of Songs 2:16 and Malachi 2:14-16.

TALK

1. Hebrews says keep the marriage bed pure and honored. What does honoring it look like, beyond avoiding sin?
2. A contract keeps score. A covenant keeps showing up. Which one has your marriage, or your thinking about marriage, been closer to?
3. Where has porn or fantasy taught you something about women that isn't true?
4. What would it take for you to have an honest conversation about this with your wife, in daylight, outside the bedroom?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Proverbs 5:15-21.

5. This father tells his son to delight in the wife of his youth. Why do you think he puts it in terms of joy and not just rules?
6. What would it take to rebuild trust after it's been broken in this part of a marriage?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Married men set a time for that daylight conversation. Single and divorced men give a brother the filter password, or name the one step they'll take toward that this week.

CHAPTER 21

Your Daughter Is Watching

FOR THE HOST

Fathers of daughters often feel unsure how to speak into their girls' lives, especially as they get older. This chapter gives them a simple way in. Delight in who she is, and honor her mother where she can see it. Men without daughters still have a part here. Every girl in a church needs steady, kind men around her, and every man can be one.

OPEN

What's one thing your daughter, niece, or granddaughter does that makes you laugh?

READ ALOUD

Zephaniah 3:14-17.

TALK

1. God rejoices over His people with singing. When did your daughter last hear you delight in her for who she is, not what she did?
2. How you treat her mother this week is a preview of the man she'll marry. What preview has she been getting?
3. What will she learn about a father from how you handle your phone, your temper, and your time?
4. Men without daughters, who's a girl or young woman in your life who needs a steady man to be kind to her and to honor her?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Mark 5:35-43.

5. Jesus took a little girl by the hand and spoke to her tenderly. What does His gentleness show a father?
6. What would your daughter say is the best thing about you? The hardest?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each father names one specific thing he'll tell his daughter he loves about who she is.

CHAPTER 22

Give Your Son a Name, a Hill, and a Day

FOR THE HOST

Many men never got a clear word from their own fathers that they were men. This chapter asks them to give their sons what they may not have gotten. Some will grieve that tonight. Let them. Then turn toward the boys in their lives. A name, a hill, and a day are things any father, grandfather, uncle, or mentor can give, with a parent's blessing.

OPEN

What's something your father, or another man, once said to you that you still remember word for word?

READ ALOUD

Deuteronomy 6:4-9.

TALK

1. Moses tells fathers to talk about God's words at home, on the road, at bedtime, and in the morning. What does that look like in a regular week?
2. A name, a hill, and a day. Which of the three did you get from your own father? Which did you miss?
3. What hill could you hand your son that fits him, and then sit on your hands while he climbs it?
4. One morning tells him he's a man, and a hundred ordinary weeks afterward make it so. Which part are you better at?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Genesis 48:8-16.

5. Jacob put his hands on his grandsons' heads and blessed them by name. Why did that matter so much in his family?
6. What words of blessing would you want spoken over your son on his wedding day?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each father names one thing he'll catch and name in his son this week, and the night he'll bless him out loud. Men without sons name a boy they could do this for, with his parents' blessing.

PART FIVE

The Long Road

Part Five is about lasting. Work, feelings, seasons, the years nobody claps, a plan on paper, and the men who stay. It's where the group stops being a class and starts being something men keep.

Host, by now the table should be running itself. Hand the opening question to a different man each week. Let another man run the close. Part of going first is making room for the next man to do it. Before the last meeting, ask the group what's next. Another round with new men, a second pass through the book, or a standing breakfast. Don't let it just end.

CHAPTER 23

You Were Made for a Work

FOR THE HOST

Work is where most men spend most of their waking hours, and many have never thought of it as part of what God made them for. Men who hate their jobs, men between jobs, and retired men will all hear this differently. Make room for each. The point isn't that every job is a dream. It's that God is a worker, and a man can serve Him in honest work wherever he's planted.

OPEN

What was your first paying job, and what did it teach you?

READ ALOUD

John 5:16-20, then Genesis 2:15.

TALK

1. Jesus says His Father is always at work, and so is He. What does it change to know God is a worker?
2. Is your job something you endure for the weekend, or part of the work you were made for? What would it take to see it the second way?
3. Men between jobs, retired men, men stuck in a job they hate. What's the work God's handed you in this season?
4. When the old plot is gone, God gives you a new one. Who's someone you've watched find new work late in life?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Ecclesiastes 2:17-26.

5. The Teacher hated his work when he tried to make it mean everything. What changed when he saw it as a gift from God?
6. If you lost your job tomorrow, what would still be your work?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man names one part of his job he'll do for the Lord this week and keep to himself.

CHAPTER 24

Feelings Are the Dash, Not the Wheel

FOR THE HOST

This meeting can open up talk about depression, anxiety, and grief. Take it seriously. A man who's been in a long darkness may say so for the first time tonight. Thank him. Say clearly that seeing a doctor or a counselor is part of being steadfast, not a failure of faith. Then help every man practice the two lines, naming the feeling and choosing the step anyway.

OPEN

What's the weather inside you tonight, in one word?

READ ALOUD

Psalm 42.

TALK

1. The psalmist talks to his own soul. "Why, my soul, are you downcast?" When was the last time you questioned a feeling instead of obeying it?
2. Some men ignore the dash completely. Some let it drive the truck. Which are you?
3. Which feeling has been steering you lately? Tired, angry, lonely, restless, afraid?
4. If a man at this table is in a darkness that won't lift, what should he do this week? Say it plainly, so every man knows getting help is part of being steadfast.

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read 1 Kings 19:1-8.

5. After a great victory, Elijah wanted to die. God gave him sleep and food before He gave him a word. What does that tell you about caring for a man in a dark stretch?
6. Who is a brother you should check on this week because you know he's been low?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man starts each day this week with two lines to God. "Father, I'm feeling this." "Here's what I'll do anyway."

CHAPTER 25

Every Season Still Counts

FOR THE HOST

Every man at the table is in a season, and most of them wish they were in a different one. The young father wants sleep. The empty nester wants purpose. The retired man wants to matter. This chapter says every season has a job. Help each man find his on one line with a verb in it.

OPEN

What season of life are you in, in a sentence?

READ ALOUD

Ecclesiastes 3:1-14.

TALK

1. There's a time for everything. Which season are you trying to skip or rush through?
2. February has a job. What's the job of a season that feels like waiting?
3. What did an older man you respect do with a hard or quiet season of his life?
4. What would you tell a man ten years younger about the season you're in now?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Psalm 92:12-15.

5. The righteous still bear fruit in old age. What does fruit look like in the season you're in?
6. What did the hardest season of your life teach you that an easy one couldn't?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man writes his season's assignment on one line with an action word, and names the first piece he'll do by next Tuesday.

CHAPTER 26

What You Are Building When Nobody Claps

FOR THE HOST

Most of a man's real work is unseen. This meeting is about the rhythm that keeps him steady when nobody's watching or clapping. Keep the index cards small. A rhythm a man can live for seven days is worth more than an ideal he quits on Thursday. Encourage men to live it quietly and not announce it.

OPEN

When was the last time someone thanked you for something ordinary?

READ ALOUD

1 Corinthians 3:10-15, then Hebrews 6:10-12.

TALK

1. Paul says some build with gold and some with straw, and the fire will show which. What in your life would survive the fire?
2. Hebrews says God won't forget the work and love you've shown. Why do men need to hear that?
3. What's in your rhythm right now, the handful of things that stay put every week? What should be?
4. Big days only harvest what ordinary days planted. What are you planting?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Matthew 25:14-23.

5. The master praised the servants for being faithful with what they had. What has God put in your hands to be faithful with?
6. What would you keep doing even if nobody ever noticed?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man writes his rhythm on an index card, puts it on his dash, and lives it seven days without mentioning it.

CHAPTER 27

Write the Next Move

FOR THE HOST

Tonight men bring a page. Some will have written ten careful lines. Some will have nothing. Both are fine. Give the man with nothing ten minutes at the table to write his bottom line, the one thing he'll do this week, with a verb, a person, and a day. The point isn't a perfect plan. It's a plan on paper that gets done.

OPEN

Have you ever written down a plan for your life? What happened to it?

READ ALOUD

Habakkuk 2:1-3, then Proverbs 16:1-9.

TALK

1. God tells Habakkuk to write the vision down and make it plain. Why does paper matter?
2. A plan needs a verb, a person, and a day. Which of the three do your plans usually lack?
3. Proverbs says a man plans his course and the Lord establishes his steps. How do you hold a plan with an open hand?
4. Bring the page you've been working. Read the bottom line to the man beside you.

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read Luke 14:28-30.

5. Jesus talks about a builder who counts the cost before he starts. What cost have you not counted on your plan?
6. Who could read your page and tell you the truth about it?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Each man signs and dates his page and names the bottom line he'll get done before the next meeting.

CHAPTER 28

These Men Are My Brothers

FOR THE HOST

This is the last chapter, but it shouldn't be the last meeting. Spend real time letting men say what they've seen in each other. Then talk about what's next. Another round with new men, a second pass through the book, or a standing breakfast. A group of men who have done this together is rare. Don't let it quietly dissolve.

OPEN

What's one thing a man at this table said this year that you're still thinking about?

READ ALOUD

Proverbs 17:17, then Hebrews 10:23-25.

TALK

1. A friend loves at all times, and a brother is born for a time of trouble. When has this table been there in trouble?
2. Hebrews tells us not to give up meeting together. What's the most likely thing to make this group quit?
3. Go around the table. Say one thing you've seen God do in the man to your left.
4. What happens next? Who are you going to bring to the next table?

GOING DEEPER

For groups that meet longer, or a second night on the same chapter, read 2 Timothy 4:9-18.

5. Paul names the men who stayed and the men who left, near the end of his life. What kind of man do you want to be in someone else's list?
6. What would you want your brothers to say about you at your funeral?

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Read the four marks slowly together, one time. Then each man names the next Tuesday he'll show up for a brother, and the group sets its next date before anyone stands.

Twenty Minutes a Week

Chapter twelve asks every man to find one brother and ask him for twenty minutes a week for three months, at the same hour, no matter what. Once the group ends, those twenty minutes are how the work keeps going. Meet in person if you can, and by phone if you can't, but keep the day and the hour, and if something truly can't be moved, set the makeup time before you cancel.

Both men answer every question, because this is two brothers and not a mentor with a project, even when one is thirty years older. What's said stays between the two of you unless one of you is in danger. Start each week by asking about last week's answer, since that is usually where the real conversation is. Open with one honest question, read one short passage, and close with one move each man will make before you meet again. Questions like these are enough to begin. What's the heaviest thing on you right now? What have you known for a while that you need to do? When the day goes wrong, where do you go?

End every meeting by praying for each other out loud, briefly and by name. Somewhere around the third or fourth week, one of you will want to quit, so name that week when it comes and keep the hour anyway. If one of you falls off, the other one calls without waiting to be called. At twelve weeks, decide together whether to go another round. Most men do.